Background Guide for the United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund (UNICEF)

Committee Overview and Mandate

Introduction

The United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund (UNICEF) is a specialized agency of the United Nations under the UN Department of Human Rights and Humanitarian Affairs. UNICEF was established under UN General Assembly[1] Resolution 57 in December 1946 as a relief organization for children in Europe facing famine and disease after World War II. In 1953 the UN extended the mandate of UNICEF indefinitely.

Governance, Mandate, Membership and Structure

UNICEF is active in more than 190 Member States through Member State programs and National Committees organized by UNICEF. UNICEF is nonpartisan and committed to a policy of non-discrimination. UNICEF prioritizes the most disadvantaged children and the Member States with the greatest need. UNICEF is mandated by the United Nations General Assembly as an advocate for the protection of children's rights, guided by the *Convention on the Rights of the Child*. UNICEF insists that the survival, protection, and development of children are imperative to universal development and to the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). UNICEF looks to expand children's opportunities to reach their full potential, which includes gaining access to education. UNICEF aims to promote equal rights of girls and supports their full participation in the political, social, and economic development of their communities through programs within Member States. By mobilizing both political will and material resources to help Member States ensure a "first call for children," UNICEF is able to build their capacity to form appropriate policies and deliver services for children and their families. UNICEF works to attain sustainable human development, as stressed by the international community, along with striving to realize the vision of peace and social progress as described in the Charter of the United Nations. UNICEF accomplishes its goals by staging global information campaigns, intensifying partnership both within UN organs and among Member State governments, helping to provide infrastructure with support given to state and regional based initiatives, and through assistance to Member States with policymaking and implementation.

[1] The General Assembly is one of the six main organs of the United Nations

Ensuring Access to Primary Education for All

Background

Ensuring universal access to primary education—highlighted in Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 4—is critical for insuring the basic human right of every individual to live a productive, fulfilling, and meaningful life. UNICEF must strengthen its collaborative efforts with other multilateral organizations, Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), governments of Member States, and the private sector to identify and implement innovative strategies to reach out to the most marginalized groups, including slum dwellers, indigenous peoples, and the mentally and physically challenged.

Promoting Education for Girls

UNICEF aims to enhance the education of all children, with a specific focus on ensuring that all girls complete primary school[2]. Girls who are more educated have significantly greater economic opportunities and employment options. UNICEF particularly focuses on vulnerable groups of children and their educational needs.[3] "Take Action for Girls and Women with Global Goals" is a media campaign run by the United Nations Foundation, which promotes the SDGs and the achievement of Goal 5 to "Achieve gender equality for all women and girls."[4] Ensuring that all girls receive the same education is a primary focus for UNICEF, as education is considered a vital component in achieving equality for women and girls. In 2015, UNICEF estimated that 80% of girls in certain Southwest Asian Member States never would attend primary school, as compared to 16% of boys. Girls are prevented from going to school for many reasons, including school fees, societal norms, fear of sexual and gender based violence (SGBV), and economic and societal demands.

UNICEF looks to ensure that girls are not held back from attending school by promoting a multifaceted approach to ensuring that girls go to school and that they stay in school. The high dropout rate among girls is a continuing problem,[5] yet empowering women and girls through

[2] UNICEF, Gender Equality 2016
[3] UNICEF, About https://www.unicef.org/about/who/index_introduction.html
[4] United Nations Foundation http://www.unfoundation.org/how-to-help/take-action/
[5] UN DSPD, Youth and Education, p. 1.

education is vital to achieving the 2030 Sustainable Development Agenda[6]. Mainstreaming gender equality can encourage sustainable development within the education sector,[7] which can be achieved through the work of civil society, development agencies, Member States, multilateral institutions such as the World Bank and the UN Development Programme, and the private sector[8]. In line with SDG 4, ensuring quality education, UNESCO, the UN Population Fund (UNFPA) and UN-Women have partnered on a number of projects to empower girls through education[9]. In order to help Member States achieve gender equality in education, the United Nations *Girls' Education Initiative* (UNGEI) puts the rights of girls first, supports life skills-based education, and promotes female role models in education[10]. To further promote gender equality, States can implement UNICEF's *Child Friendly Schools* initiative to provide a gender-sensitive environment that is conducive to learning at all levels[11].

Funding & Infrastructure

Primary education is funded through UNICEF under five main categories, including regular resources, thematic funding, emergency funding and appeals, pooled funding and trust funds, and "other resources."[12] The regular resources, or money from donors without restrictions on its use, are flexible and help to meet the basic needs of children.[13] Thematic funding is earmarked by donors to support specific objectives from the *Strategic Plan of 2014-2017* at a global, regional, and Member State level for long-term planning and sustainability of programs.[14] Emergency funding and appeals are used to provide lifesaving assistance through using the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) programs.[15] Pooled funding are other resources which can be administered directly or jointly, while multi-donor trust funds are pooled funds that efficiently mobilize financial resources donated voluntarily.[16] Finally, "other resources" are allocated to fund development activities as outlined in country programs.[17]

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[6] UN General Assembly, Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (A/RES/70/1), 2015
[7] UN General Assembly, Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (A/RES/70/1), 2015
[8] UNESCO, Education for All Movement
[9] UNESCO, Three UN agencies join forces to boost education for girls and young women. http://en.unesco.org/news/three-agencies-join-forces-boost-education-adolescent-girls-and-young-women
[10] UNICEF, Girls' Education and Gender Equality https://www.unicef.org/education/bege_70640.html
[11] UNICEF, Child Friendly Schools https://www.unicef.org/cfs/
[12] UNICEF, Types of Funding https://www.unicef.org/publicpartnerships/66662_66849.html
[13] UNICEF, Regular Resources https://www.unicef.org/publicpartnerships/66662_66850.html
[14] UNICEF, Thematic Funding https://www.unicef.org/publicpartnerships/66662_66851.html
[15] UNICEF, Humanitarian Funding https://www.unicef.org/publicpartnerships/66662_66853.html
[16] UNICEF, Pooled Funding and Trust Funds https://www.unicef.org/publicpartnerships/66662_66855.html

[17] UNICEF, Other Resources Regular https://www.unicef.org/publicpartnerships/66662_66852.html

In order to provide primary education to all students regardless of gender, race, or other factors, several programs exist to build upon the funding that UNICEF offers. For example, *The Global Fund for Children* invests in organizations that already exist to provide primary education to children who belong to vulnerable populations. Through NGO and Member State specific programs, funding can be provided in a more efficient way to primary education. There are significant financial barriers that must be overcome to ensure primary education for all children, including providing special accommodations for disabled students, training for teachers, and providing a physical classroom or school in areas in which there are none.

Utilizing Information and Communication Technologies (ICT) in Education

UNICEF recognizes the important role that Information and Communications Technologies (ICT) can have in ensuring access to primary education for all. In 2014, UNICEF partnered with Results for Development (R4D), a global nonprofit organization, and its initiative, the Center for Education Innovators (CEI), in order to identify innovative education programs around the world, many of which utilize ICTs. Such programs include Sudan's *Can't Wait To Learn* program, which creates an accelerated learning program utilizing a digitized curriculum on tablets in order to enable out-of-school children to catch up while they are unable to attend formal school. In addition, Peru's *EduTrac* program uses SMS technology to allow school administrators, parent committees, tutors, and other educators to provide data on schools in geographically remote or otherwise inaccessible areas. Allowing the sharing of data enables more effective government oversight and management of the educational system. UNICEF encourages the further integration of ICTs in education in order to provide more inclusive learning environments.

UNICEF aims to ensure the rights of all children, including children with disabilities. With nearly 1 in 10 children having a disability, they are considered to be one of the most stigmatized groups of children worldwide. ICTs can have an especially important impact on the education of children with disabilities, allowing them to have access to the quality education that they deserve. UNICEF strongly supports the use of Assistive Technologies (AT) in classrooms, which cover a broad range of tools that give support to children with disabilities, including hearing aids, communication software, computer-based instruction, and other aids. Providing inclusive education environments allows children with disabilities to thrive among their peers and in their communities; utilizing ATs and ICTs in primary education offers children with disabilities the opportunity to participate as equals in a classroom.

Conclusion

UNICEF aims to ensure universal access to primary education. Education is a basic human right—affirmed in documents such as the *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*—and is necessary to

give each person the opportunity to live a productive and meaningful life and to contribute to their community. Guided by SDG 4, which is ensuring that all girls and boys have access to free, equitable, and quality primary and secondary education leading to relevant and effective learning outcomes, UNICEF has a special focus on promoting education for girls. By strengthening collaborative efforts with Member States, NGOs, the private sector, and multilateral organizations, UNICEF can assist Member States with funding and infrastructure of education and can better utilize ICTs for education.

Questions to Consider

1. Why is it important to ensure that all girls receive the same education? How will this achieve equality for women and girls?
2. What changes can governments make to existing policies to increase primary school enrolment and attendance? What steps do governments need to take to increase funding for education, especially in Least Developed Countries (LDCs)?
3. What are the obstacles to primary school for all, in terms of enrolment and attendance, that children continue to experience?
4. What are some key issues regarding funding for UNICEF?
5. What are the particular needs that should be addressed regarding vulnerable groups and primary education?

Helpful Links

1. https://www.unicef.org/mdg/education.html
2. https://www.unicef.org/appeals/funding_trends.html
3. https://www.unicef.org/about/execboard/files/2013-ABL4-UNICEF_integrated_budget-11Jul2013.pdf
4. https://www.charitynavigator.org/index.cfm?bay=search.summary&orgid=4617#

Regional Organizations

African Union-
https://www.au.int/

Arab League-
http://www.arableagueonline.org/

Association of South East Asian Nations-
http://asean.org/

Asian Cooperation Dialogue-
http://www.acd-dialogue.org/

European Union-
https://europa.eu/european-union/index_en

Economic Community of West African States-
http://www.ecowas.int/

Organization of American States-
http://www.oas.org/en/

Pacific Islands Forum-
http://www.forumsec.org/

Union of South American Nations-
http://www.unasur.int/en

International Agencies

Europol-
https://www.europol.europa.eu/

International Police Association-
http://www.ipa-iac.org/

INTERPOL-
https://www.interpol.int/

International Criminal Court-
https://www.icc-cpi.int/

United Nations Entities

International Peace and Security-
http://www.un.org/en/sections/priorities/international-peace-and-security/
Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
http://www.unocha.org/

United Nations Assistance Mission to Iraq-
http://www.uniraq.org/index.php?lang=en

United Nations Charter-
http://www.un.org/en/charter-united-nations/

United Nations Country Team Iraq-
http://www.uniraq.com/index.php?option=com_k2&view=item&layout=item&id=944&Itemid=479&lang=en

United Nations Developmental Assistance Framework-
https://www.un.org/ecosoc/sites/www.un.org.ecosoc/files/files/en/qcpr/doco-summary-brief-on-undaf-march2016.pdf

United Nations Department of Peacekeeping Operations-
http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/about/dpko/

United Nations Department of Political Affairs-
http://www.un.org/undpa/en

United Nations Development Programme in Nigeria-
http://www.ng.undp.org/

United Nations Office of the Special Advisor on Africa
http://www.un.org/en/africa/osaa/

United Nations Peacekeeping-
http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/

United Nations Security Council-
http://www.un.org/en/sc/

United Nations Security Council Counter-Terrorism Committee-
https://www.un.org/sc/ctc/

United Nations Security Council Documents-
http://www.un.org/en/sc/documents/

United Nations Supervision Mission in Syria-
http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/missions/unsmis/